

While there had been half-hearted efforts to develop an iron and steel industry in India, it was thought best to avoid creating competition for their British counterparts. Most endeavours, such as the Bengal Iron and Steel Company set up in 1905, failed. So India imported about 96 per cent of its railway supplies from Britain and Belgium.

When rails switched from iron to steel, railway companies continued to import them, until Indian industrialist Jamsetji Nusserwanji Tata, and later his son Dorabji, appeared on the scene. Despite the lack of Government support, the Tatas conducted extensive research and by 1907, had issued a prospectus for the all-Indian Tata Iron and Steel Company (TISCO). Production of steel ingots began in 1912 and the following year, TISCO began manufacturing steel rails. By 1916, production had gone up to 9,072 tonnes of steel rails and sections.

With World War I (1914–18), steel imports dropped, leaving the Government no option but to rely on TISCO to meet the demand. By 1938–39, the company produced 99 per cent of the rails bought in India.

## INDIAN IRON AND STEEL COMPANY

Iron production in India became a reality after the Bengal Iron Works Company set up an open-top blast furnace in Kulti near Hiraipur (modern-day Jharkhand) in 1870. Founded by James Erskine, the company produced cast iron. By 1889, it was taken over by the Bengal Iron and Steel Company and provisions were made to produce steel. The Indian Iron and Steel Company (IISCO) was established as an industrial enterprise in 1918, absorbing BIS in 1936 and steel production began on a regular basis. The Steel Corporation of Bengal became a part of IISCO in 1937, bringing with it the Napuria and Hiraipur Works. Together, they came to be known as the Burnpur Works. Post-Independence, the Indian Government took over IISCO in 1972, which became a subsidiary of the Steel Authority of India in 1979.